

the former who struck the fatal blow. The leader of this new Median state was Cyaxares (Uvakhshatara), whose reign lasted until 585 B. C. It was he who really made the name of Medes a terror over all western Asia. It is difficult to follow his course, for the people whom he led were men of action, not writers of tablets, like the Babylonians. We can, however, see them possessing all Assyria after Nineveh was laid waste, and with it the whole of the great northern valley between the Tigris and Euphrates, including those Babylonian cities which had acknowledged the Assyrian overlordship. By 560 their dominion was acknowledged as far west as the Halys, which separated them from the kingdom of Lydia, over which Croesus, of proverbial memory, was now king (560-546 B. C.).

While these conquests were proceeding, and the world seemed ready to bow down at the feet of the overpowering Medes, there had been born in Anshan, as the son of Cambyses, the boy Cyrus, who grew to manhood as king of Anshan, and as a tributary prince beneath the authority of Astyages, king of the Medes. It was impossible that a man such as he should long remain beneath the sway of another. In 553 he arose against Astyages, and, according to the story which Nabonidus has preserved for us, Astyages was delivered bound into his hands by his own treacherous troops. In 550 Cyrus took Ecbatana and sacked it, and brought there to an end the Median power. The Persians under Cyrus now fell heir to all that the Medes had won, and in 549 turned against Croesus, who was taken in 546. The Lydian empire was now also brought under Persian control, and before the end of 545 the entire peninsula of Asia Minor was a part of the new Persian empire, divided into satrapies and governed with a strong hand. Even